

What else to watch: *The African Queen* (1951) ■ *Deliverance* (1972) ■ *Apocalypse Now* (1979, p.338) ■ *Fitzcarraldo* (1982) ■ *The Mosquito Coast* (1986) ■ *Platoon* (1986) ■ *El Dorado* (1988) ■ *The New World* (2005) ■ *Apocalypto* (2006)

German reviewer at the time as “a color-drenched, violently physical moving painting.” This look, combined with a churchlike musical score, gives the movie an almost mythical quality.

Smashing taboos

Aguirre is a monstrous figure, so overtaken with ambition that he completely ignores all social rules and human obligations. He shows no mercy or sympathy. Left alone in the jungle, he contemplates an incestuous relationship with his teenage daughter. “I, the Wrath of God, will marry my own daughter, and with her I will found the purest

dynasty the world has ever seen.” He lets nothing stand in his way. When a man talks of turning back, he says, “That man is a head taller than me. That may change.” Then he beheads him while he is still talking. Aguirre’s brutality and resilience are so breathtaking, we might almost find him heroic.

But Herzog leaves us in no doubt that Aguirre’s ambition is futile and destructive. The final scene shows Aguirre alone on a raft, and his only company is hundreds of monkeys. He grabs one, and his heroic declamation, “I am Aguirre, I am the Wrath of God. Who else is with me?” is addressed

“I am the **Wrath of God!** The earth I pass will **see me and tremble.**”

Aguirre / Aguirre, the Wrath of God

“
Mr Herzog... is a poet who constantly surprises us with unexpected juxtapositions... This is a splendid and haunting work.
Vincent Canby
The New York Times, 1977
”

to the monkeys. The scene is bathetic in the extreme. Aguirre is a man to be ridiculed and pitied, a man who has brought nothing but destruction through his own folly. ■

From the outset of the expedition, Aguirre’s eyes shine with the insanity of his obsession. The movie’s message warns of the dangers of myths on the human psyche.

